

THE LONG COMMUTE TO CLARITY

BEFORE TILAK VARMA LEARNED TO CLEAR THE ROPES, HE LEARNED TO WAIT — 60 DAILY KILOMETRES ON A SCOOTER THAT TAUGHT HIM PATIENCE BEFORE POWER.

V. V. Subrahmanyam
sportstar@thehindu.co.in



CHECK OUR
LATEST VIDEO
SERIES

Thirty kilometres from Hyderabad's bustle, at the quiet NexGen Cricket Academy Ground in Thummukunta, Tilak Varma readies for another season — this time leading his State, before rejoining India's squad for the Australia T20s later this month. Yet, for all the new weight of fame and international travel, his story began in the lanes of the Old City.

Every morning, a young Tilak would hop onto his coach Salam Bayash's two-wheeler for the 60-kilometre round trip across Hyderabad's chaotic streets, from his home in Balapur to the suburb of Lingampally six days a week for coaching. Amid the honking and rush, those rides forged something the city traffic lacked — discipline. Years later, that same discipline defines Tilak's cricket.

Fresh from his exploits at the Asia Cup, where he played a sensational match-winning innings against Pakistan in the final, the 22-year-old from Hyderabad now looks ahead with purpose.

Tilak insists his technique hasn't changed much. "The only thing I feel is that I'm more confident in playing some strokes — not only picking the gaps but also clearing the ground with greater ease," he smiled.

Yet, for Tilak, confidence no longer means aggression alone. In the Asia Cup final, it meant control — the ability to hold back when instinct said